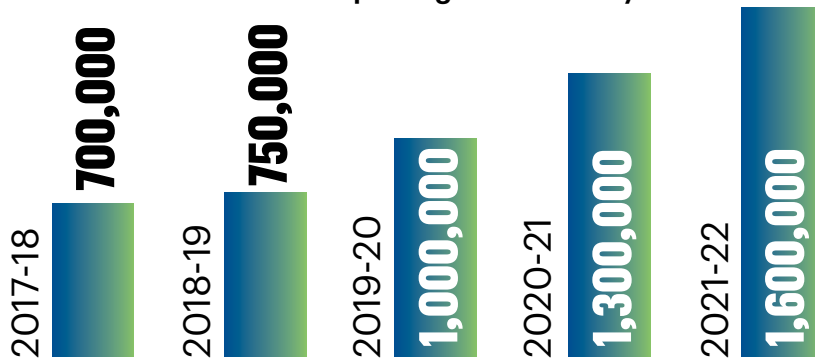
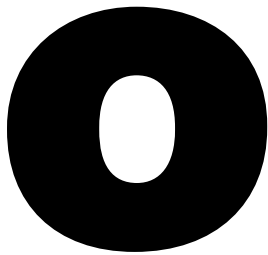


G R O W I N G H E A P

E-waste accumulation is exploding in the country



Note All figures in tonnes; **Source** Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) report titled 'E-Waste Management in India 2021-22'



ON JANUARY 29, during his monthly radio programme *Mann Ki Baat*, Prime Minister Narendra Modi highlighted the issue of electronic waste (e-waste) accumulation in India. He referred to a report by the UN, stating that a staggering 50 million tonnes of e-waste is discarded annually. Modi brought out the context of this scale by pointing out that the weight of all commercial planes ever constructed put together would be less than that of the e-waste being generated. In fact, he likened the rate of e-waste disposal to discarding 800 laptops every single second.

The PM's decision to address the mounting problem of e-waste is not without reason. India currently ranks third among the largest generators of e-waste globally, behind only China and the US. The

volume of e-waste in India has witnessed a significant surge—from 700,000 tonnes in 2017-18 to 1.6 million tonnes in 2021-22 (*see chart*). This explosion is being fed by a parallel explosion of electronic goods' consumption in India, with over 17 million TV sets, 148 million smartphones, 14 million refrigerators, 19 million audio devices and 6.5 million washing machines being sold across the country annually and growing, according to industry experts.

However, the issue extends beyond mere waste management. It also poses a significant environmental and health concern. E-waste consists of various hazardous substances, including lead, mercury and cadmium, which, if not disposed of properly, can contaminate the environment and lead to health problems. Adding to the challenge, a staggering 85 per cent of burgeoning e-waste is managed by the unorganised sector, primarily consisting of scrap dealers scattered across the country. "India's e-waste problem is complex, driven by the growing electronics market and rapid technological advancements," says Prabhu Ram, Head of the Industry

Intelligence Group (IIG) at Cyber-Media Research.

Fully aware of the enormity of this challenge, the government has acknowledged the imperative to promptly and decisively tackle the issue of e-waste, and introduced the new E-Waste (Management) Rules, 2022, which supersede the previous regulations established in 2016. "India's e-waste policy was designed in 2011 and a lot of amendments were made in 2016 and 2018. Now, we have a new set of e-waste rules which was announced in 2022. In 11 years, the policy underwent several changes, keeping in tune with global demands and our own requirements in India," says Ravi Neeladri, CEO of Cerebra Green, which offers recycling and refurbishing services to major companies.

By broadening the scope of products subject to recycling to include several new things (more on that later), establishing rigorous recycling standards, promoting the principles of a circular economy, and ensuring that only technologically advanced recyclers are involved, the new rules have a lot of muscle. But it is the diligent implementation of these rules that can result in generating value within the ecosystem and enabling India to tackle its e-waste problem. Let's take a deeper look.

SCOPE OF PRODUCTS

The government aims to broaden the scope of the new rules by expanding their coverage. Unlike the 2016 regulations, which were limited to 21 varieties of electrical and electronic equipment falling under two broad classifications, namely information technology (IT) and telecommunication equipment, as well as consumer electricals and electronics, the